

DocuStore Local Assistant — User Guide

Welcome! This guide explains how to use **DocuStore Local Assistant**, the desktop app that answers questions using **your own documents** — entirely on your computer, with no internet connection required for your files.

What is DocuStore Local Assistant?

DocuStore Local Assistant is an AI assistant you talk to like a chatbot. What makes it special:

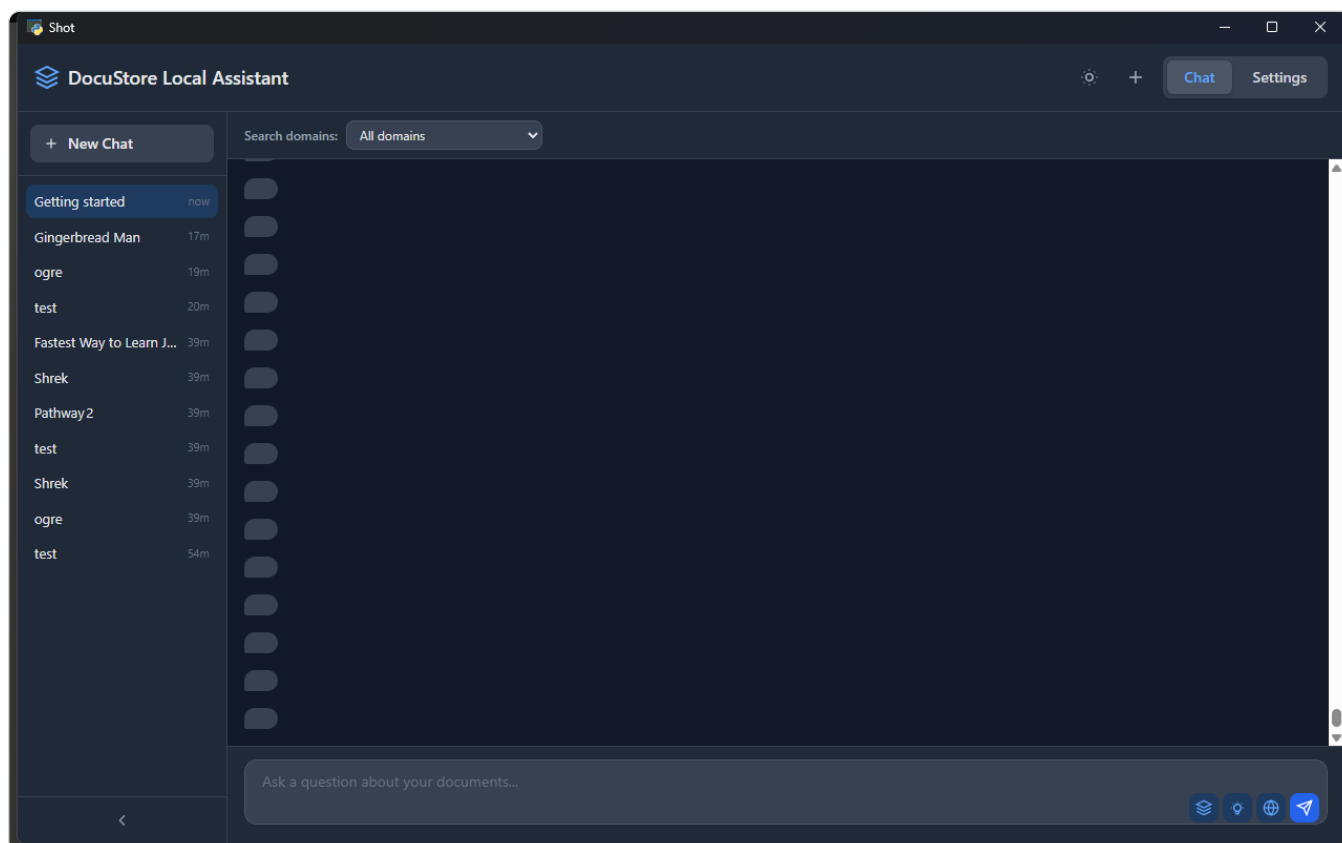
- **It searches your documents.** Upload PDFs and text files, and the assistant finds answers inside them.
 - **It is private.** Your documents are processed and stored on your own computer. Nothing is sent to the cloud.
 - **It shows its sources.** Every answer lists the documents it used, so you can check where the information came from.
 - **It can also search the web** when a question needs up-to-date information (like news or current events).
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1. Starting the App

1. Double-click the **DocuStore Local Assistant** icon on your desktop (or open it from the Start menu).
2. A **loading screen** appears with a progress bar. Wait until it says "**Ready!**" — this can take a minute or two the first time, while the app loads its AI models.
3. The main chat window then opens automatically.

The AI model must be downloaded before you can chat. See **Section 6 – Managing AI Models**. If the app was already set up for you, you can skip ahead.

2. The Main Screen



The app has two tabs at the top: **Chat** and **Settings**.

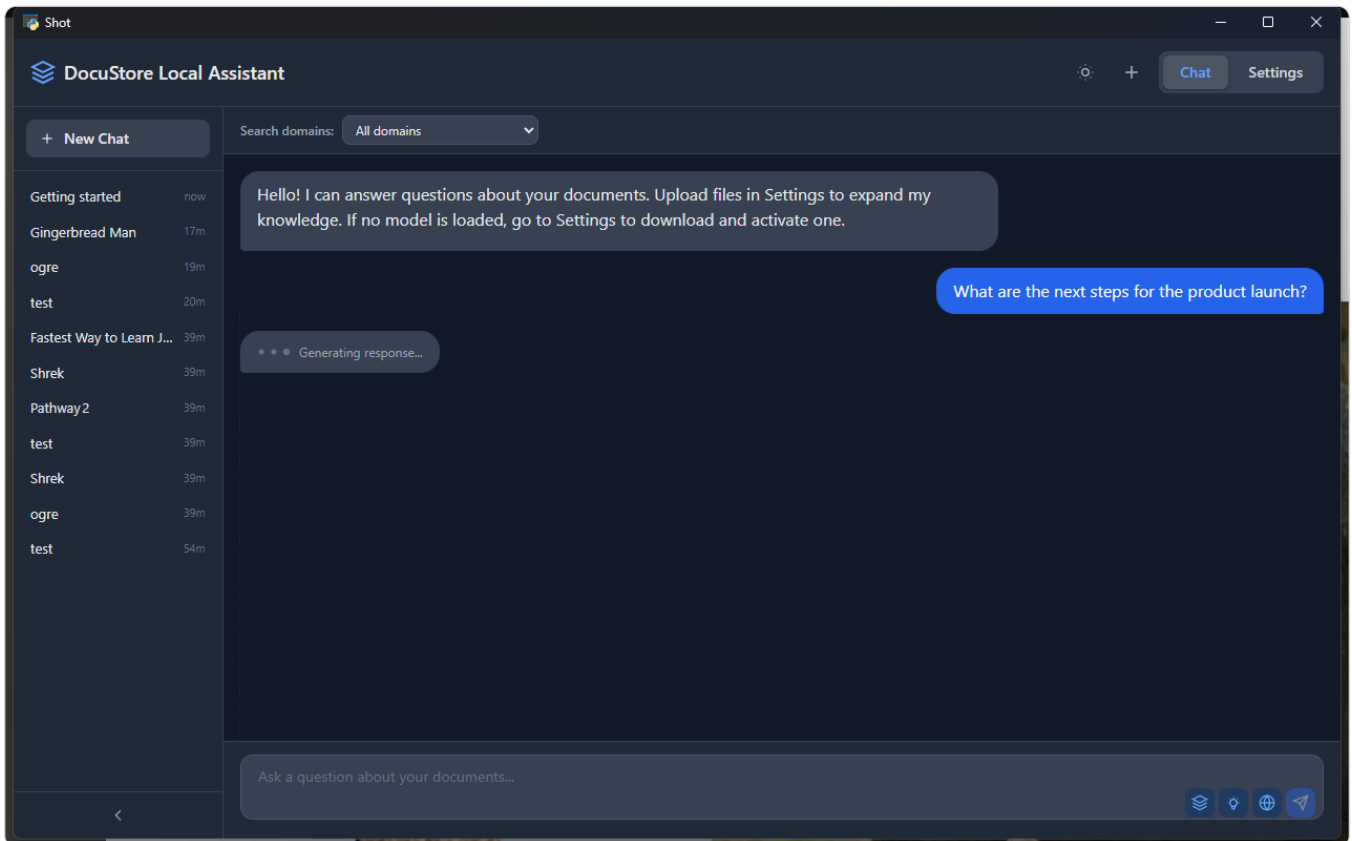
Area	What it does
Chat history (left sidebar)	Lists your previous conversations. Click one to reopen it.
New Chat	Starts a fresh conversation.
Message area (centre)	Shows your questions and the assistant's answers.
Message box (bottom)	Type your question here.
Search domains (above messages)	If you have organised your documents into groups (see Section 7), you can limit the search to one group.

The small icons inside the message box switch the assistant's options on and off — see **Section 8 – Options** for details.

3. Asking a Question

1. Click in the **message box** at the bottom of the screen.
2. Type your question in plain English, for example: *"What are the holiday entitlement rules in the employee handbook?"*
3. Press **Enter** (or click the **send** arrow).

While you wait, the app tells you what it is doing, so you always know it's working:



- **Thinking...** — preparing your question.
- **Searching your documents...** — looking for relevant information in your files.
- **Searching the web...** — looking online for current information (only when needed).
- **Generating response...** — writing the answer.

The answer then appears in the message area. You can keep chatting — the assistant remembers the conversation.

Tip: Answers on a normal computer can take a little while (usually 20–60 seconds). That's normal — the AI is working locally, not in the cloud.

4. Reading the Answers

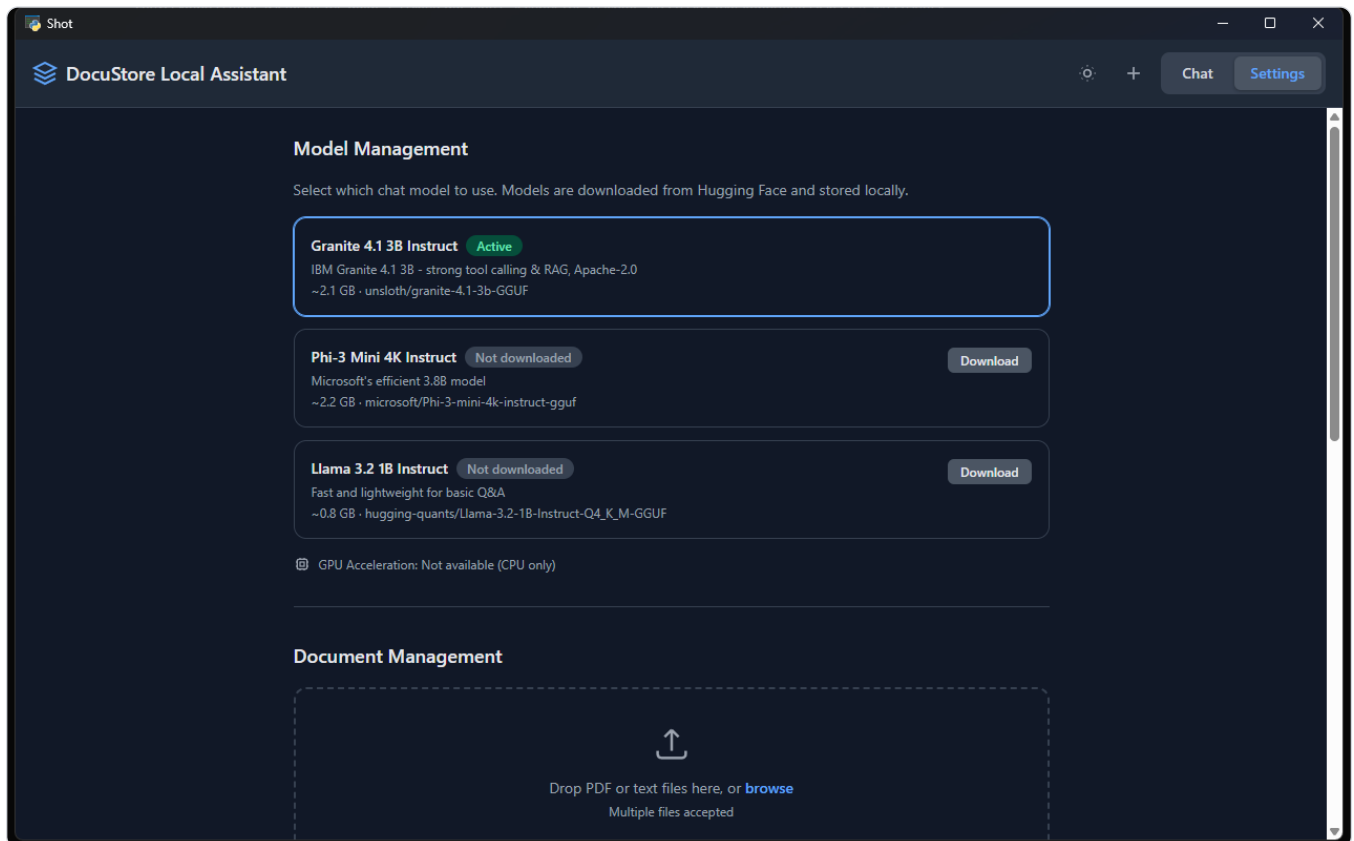
- **Thinking Process** — when the assistant "thinks through" a question, it shows a grey **Thinking Process** section above the answer. Click the heading to expand or hide it.
- **Citations (sources)** — underneath the answer you'll see blue buttons such as *Employee Handbook (p. 5)*. These are the documents the assistant used.
- Click a button to **open the source** (a document page, or a website for web results).
- Use the **arrow button** next to it to preview a short snippet of the source text.

If the assistant can't find an answer in your documents, it will say so — it won't make one up.

5. Managing Your Conversations (Sidebar)

- **New Chat** — clears the screen and starts a fresh conversation. Your previous chats stay saved.
- **Chat history** — click any saved conversation in the sidebar to reopen it.
- **Delete** — hover over a conversation and click the × button to remove it.
- **Collapse** — use the arrow at the bottom of the sidebar to hide it and give the chat more room.

6. Managing AI Models

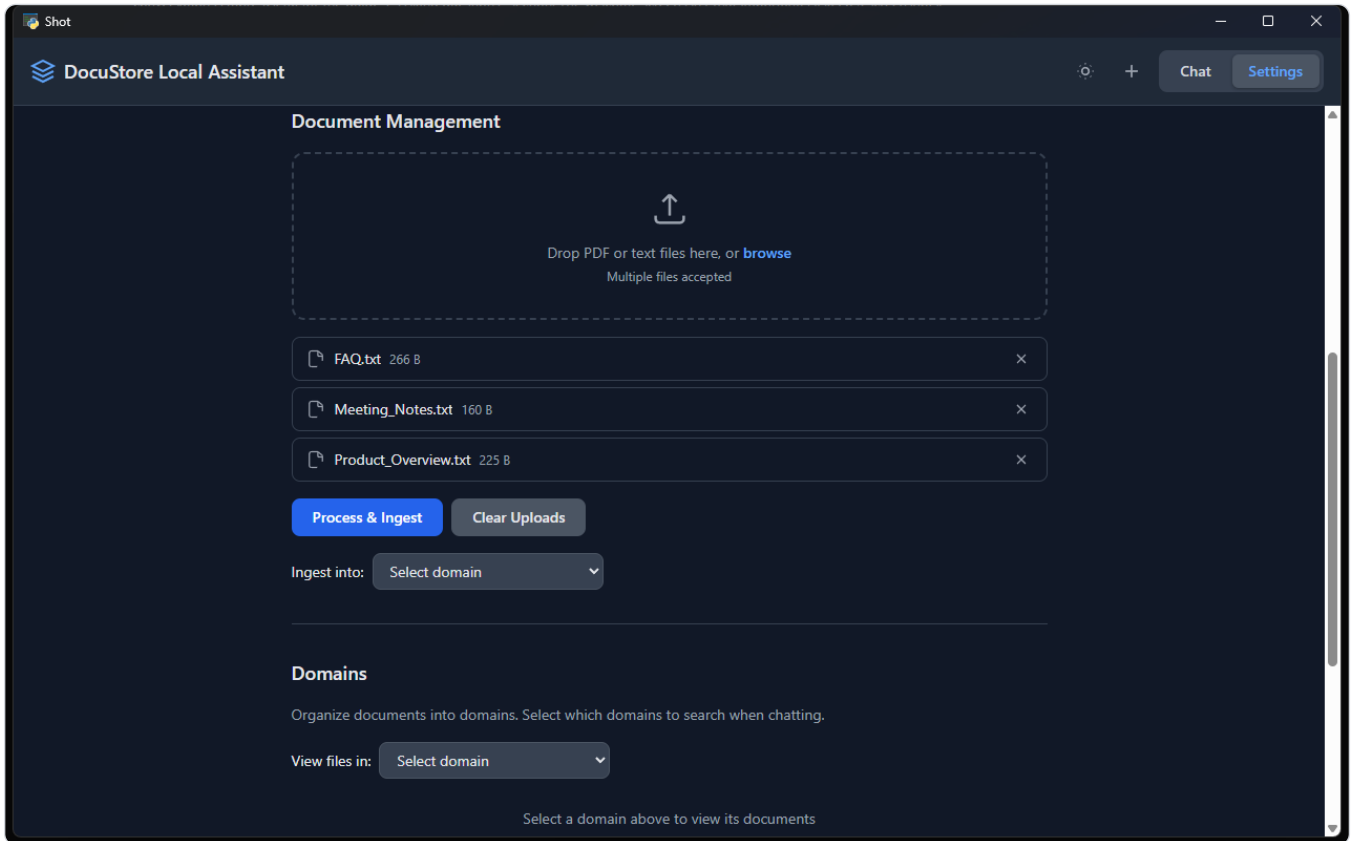


The app uses an **AI model** to write its answers. Different models balance speed and quality.

1. Open the **Settings** tab and find **Model Management**.
2. Each available model is shown in its own card: - **Active** — the model currently in use. - **Downloaded** — installed on your computer. Click **Activate** to switch to it. - **Not downloaded** — click **Download** to install it. A progress bar shows the download.
3. Under the list you'll see **GPU Acceleration**, which tells you whether the app can use your graphics card to speed up answers (this is automatic).

Recommendation: start with a smaller model (e.g. **Llama 3.2 1B**) for faster answers, and switch to a larger model (e.g. **Granite 4.1 3B**) when you want more detailed answers. Larger models are slower but smarter.

7. Managing Your Documents

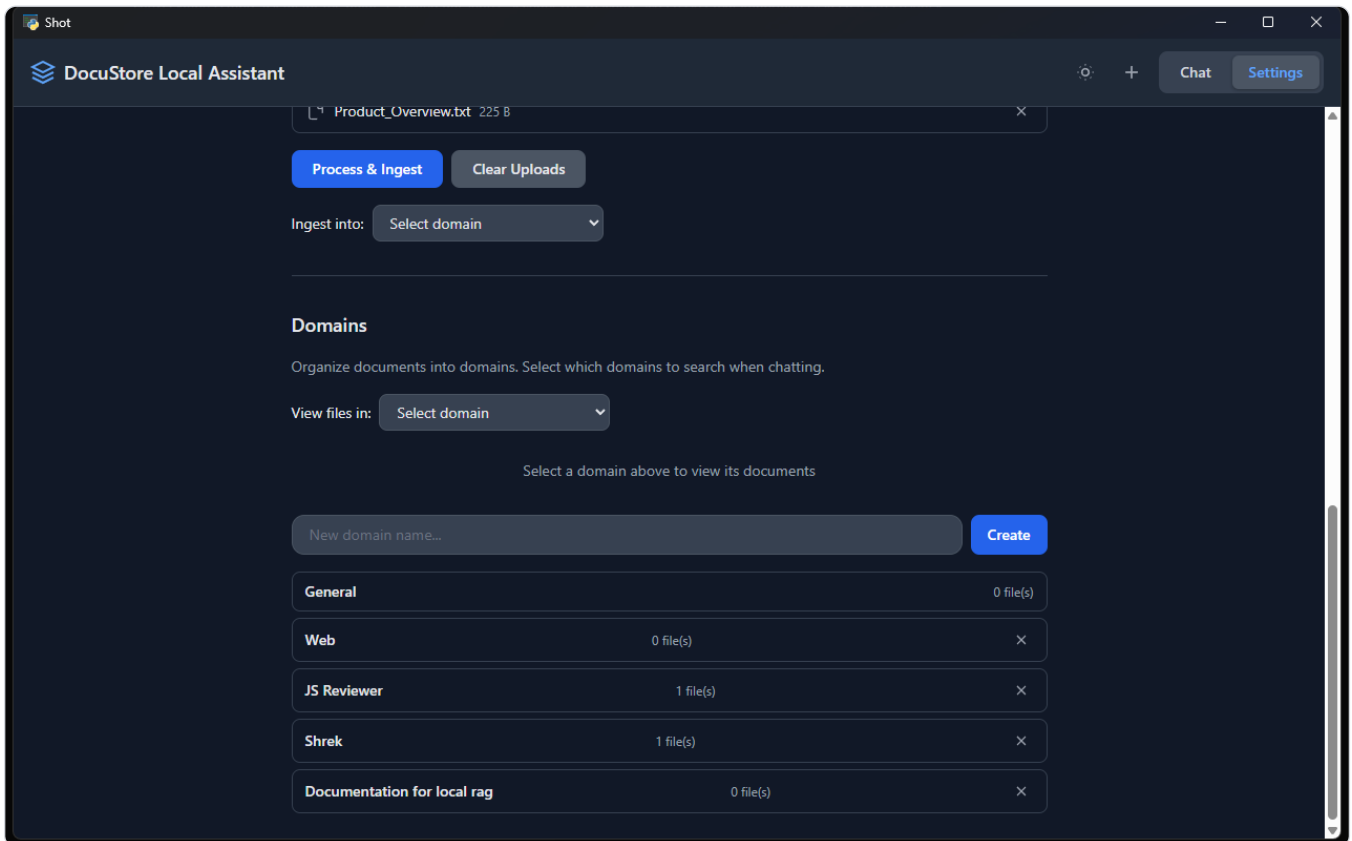


Uploading documents

1. Open the **Settings** tab and find **Document Management**.
2. **Drag and drop** PDF or text (`.txt`) files into the box — or click the box to browse and select files. You can add several at once.
3. Your files appear in the list below.
4. Choose which **domain** to put them in (see *Domains* below). If you're not using domains, keep **General**.
5. Click **Process & Ingest**. A progress bar shows the work being done. When it finishes, the assistant can search inside your new files.

Clear Uploads removes the staged files from the list without adding them to the assistant's knowledge.

Organising documents into domains



Domains are folders for grouping related documents — for example "HR Policies", "Projects", or "Training".

- **View files in a domain** — pick a domain from the list to see which documents it contains.
- **Create a domain** — type a name in the box and click **Create**.
- **Delete a domain** — click the × on a domain card to delete it and all its documents. **General** cannot be deleted.

Once you have domains set up, you can use the **Search domains** filter on the Chat screen to limit the assistant to a specific group of documents.

8. Options (the icons in the message box)

Icon	Name	What it does
Stack of layers	Document search	Searches your uploaded documents when answering. If you turn this off, the assistant answers from general knowledge only. <i>(On by default.)</i>
Lightbulb	Thinking	Lets the assistant reason through a question before answering (shows the Thinking Process section). <i>(On by default.)</i>
Globe	Web search	Lets the assistant search the internet for up-to-date information. When on, it will only search the web when the question needs current data. <i>(On by default.)</i>

Click an icon to turn it on or off. When an option is **on**, the icon is highlighted in blue.

9. Dark Mode

Click the **sun/moon icon** at the top-right of the window to switch between light and dark appearance. The app remembers your choice next time you open it.

10. Troubleshooting

Problem	What to do
The app won't load (stuck on the loading screen)	Wait a few minutes on the first launch. If it still doesn't load, close and reopen the app.
"No chat model loaded"	Open Settings → Model Management and Download then Activate a model.
Answers take a long time	A larger model is installed. Either switch to a smaller one (Section 6) or be patient — local answers are slower than online ones.
The assistant says it can't find the answer	Make sure your files were uploaded and processed with Process & Ingest , and that the Document search option is on.
Web search doesn't seem to work	Check the web search (globe) icon is highlighted. The assistant only searches the web when a question is about current, up-to-date information.
An answer looks wrong	Check the citations under the answer to verify the source, then ask a more specific question.

11. Privacy & Data

- Your documents, uploaded files, and conversations are stored **only on your computer**.
- The assistant does **not** send your questions or documents to any online service.
- The only time an internet connection is used is when **Web search** is turned on and the assistant looks up current information, or when you **download an AI model** in Settings.